

Leader boundary-spanning behavior and creative behavior: the role of need for status and creative self-efficacy

Leader
boundary-
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behavior

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Abstract

Purpose – The purpose of this research is to examine the positive relationship between leader's boundary-spanning behavior and employee creative behavior. Moreover, the research investigates a three-way effect by exploring leader's boundary-spanning behavior, need for status and creative self-efficacy on employee creative behavior.

Design/methodology/approach – The authors conducted a cross-sectional survey involving 260 supervisor-subordinate dyads from various companies in South Korea. The research tests the hypotheses through a hierarchical regression analysis.

Findings – The authors provided empirical evidence that leader's boundary-spanning behavior positively related to employee creative behavior. Moreover, the result demonstrated that the effect of leader's boundary-spanning behavior on creative behavior was the strongest in the context of high need for status and high creative self-efficacy.

Research limitations/implications – The research contributes to the three streams of literature on boundary spanning, creativity, and leadership by exploring leaders' boundary-spanning behavior, employees' need for status, and employees' creative self-efficacy.

Practical implications – The findings suggest that organizations should promote leaders' boundary-spanning behavior, thereby enhancing employees' creative behavior. Also, the study highlights the critical role of individual factors, such as the need for status and creative self-efficacy, and situational factors that determine the level of creative behavior.

Originality/value – Integrating the componential model of creativity and the interactionist perspective of creativity, this research examines the positive influence of leaders' boundary-spanning behavior on creative behavior. Furthermore, the research exhibits how leader's boundary-spanning behavior, need for status and creative self-efficacy could develop creative conditions to promote employee creative behavior.

Keywords Leader boundary-spanning behavior, Need for status, Creative self-efficacy, Creative behavior, Interactionist perspective

Paper type Research paper

Introduction

As the business environment becomes increasingly competitive and dynamic, organizations display greater interest in innovation and creativity (Acar *et al.*, 2019; Christensen-Salem *et al.*, 2021; Qu and Liu, 2021). Employee creative behavior, defined as “the production of novel and useful ideas by employees” (George and Zhou, 2001, p. 513), is a crucial aspect of



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organizational innovation. As creative behavior is a demanding and complex activity that requires various resources, scholars have examined the critical role of workplace leaders with access to these resources (Mehmood *et al.*, 2021). These leaders can gain valuable information and knowledge beyond their units or organization—referred to as *leaders' boundary-spanning behavior*—to enhance employees' work performance, including creative behavior (Salem *et al.*, 2018; Takanashi and Lee, 2019). Although diverse resources and information are required to promote creative behavior (Acar *et al.*, 2019), there is a lack of research examining the positive effect of leaders' boundary-spanning behavior on employees' creative behavior. Our study explores the role of leaders' boundary-spanning behavior and its boundary factors that stimulate employees' creative behavior to address this issue.

Amabile highlighted that “not one is sufficient for creativity in and of itself” (1983, p. 367). Prior research has noted the significance of a componential model in advancing the understanding of creativity (Kim *et al.*, 2021; Kwan *et al.*, 2018). The componential model of creativity outlines the components, namely, domain-relevant skills, creativity-relevant processes, and task motivation that are critical in influencing creativity (Amabile and Pratt, 2016). This study explores employees' need for status and creative self-efficacy as motivational and creativity-relevant components, respectively. It investigates how the joint interaction between the three components affects employees' creative behavior. By integrating the componential model of creativity (Amabile, 1983) and the interactionist perspective of organizational creativity (Woodman *et al.*, 1993), this study aims to determine *whether* and *when* leaders' external activities, such as leaders' boundary-spanning behavior, influence employees' creative behavior. Our study contributes to the three streams of literature on boundary spanning, creativity, and leadership, respectively.

First, we contribute to boundary-spanning literature by investigating the positive effect of leaders' boundary-spanning behavior on employees' creative behavior at the individual level. Mintzberg (1973) has emphasized the importance of a leader's external roles, such as liaison, spokesperson, and disseminator. Leaders' boundary-spanning behavior can help teams adapt to fast-changing environments and incorporate diverse perspectives that are valuable for exhibiting a high level of creative behavior (Salem *et al.*, 2018). However, most existing studies have focused on leaders' internal activities, such as transformational leadership, empowering leadership, and family supportive supervisory behaviors, as predictors of employees' creative behavior (e.g. Hughes *et al.*, 2018). Moreover, the boundary-spanning literature has focused on team boundary-spanning behavior and how it affects team effectiveness (e.g. Kou, 2021; Marrone, 2010). However, it is essential to examine individual boundary-spanning behavior and its effects because individuals perform boundary-spanning activities and connect with external actors (Liu *et al.*, 2018; Marrone *et al.*, 2021; Zhang and Li, 2021). Thus, this study investigates the positive impact of leaders' boundary-spanning behavior at the individual level and its boundary conditions.

Second, this study integrates the componential model of creativity (Amabile, 1983) and the interactionist perspective of creativity (Woodman *et al.*, 1993) to advance the understanding of creative behavior. Scholars have applied the componential model of creativity to examine the influence of each component on creative behavior (Kwan *et al.*, 2018). However, few researchers have investigated all three components—domain-relevant skills, creativity-relevant processes, and task motivation—using a single model. Boundary-spanning behavior could be beneficial for employees to develop new ideas, processes, or products; however, the positive impact may not be identical at the individual level. This study explores the need for status and creative self-efficacy as critical individual factors. It examines how creative conditions jointly interact to influence the relationship between leaders' boundary-spanning and creative behaviors, which has not been the focus of much research to date.

We suggest that boundary-spanning leaders can develop employees' domain-relevant skills by providing unique and valuable resources from external parties. We select employees' need

for status as a component of task motivation. As creative behavior is desirable in the workplace, employees may use it to build their work positions, thereby increasing their task motivation. We assume that this could promote employees' creativity-relevant processes, as employees with high creative self-efficacy would believe that they possess the necessary skills and ability to behave creatively.

In addition, this study applies an interactionist perspective (Woodman *et al.*, 1993) to enable a deeper understanding of employees' creative behavior. Given its complexity (Amabile and Pratt, 2016), we select situational factors (i.e. leaders' boundary-spanning behavior) and individual factors (i.e. the need for status and creative self-efficacy) and investigate the three-way interaction effect between the components. We then demonstrate that creative behavior is at its highest when leaders' boundary-spanning behavior, need for status, and creative self-efficacy are high.

Finally, this study adds to the leadership literature by considering leaders' boundary-spanning behavior as a critical driver of employees' creative behavior. Prior studies have primarily focused on internal leadership behaviors and how they influence employee outcomes, including creative behavior (e.g. Mehmood *et al.*, 2021). However, as leaders reach out to external parties and coordinate work activities to attain task objectives, we posit that their external activities, such as boundary-spanning behavior, can provide unique and valuable resources to perform creative behavior. This study contributes to the leadership literature by focusing on leaders' bridging roles outside and inside work organizations, which prior studies have overlooked.

Theoretical background and hypothesis development

Leader boundary-spanning behavior and employee creative behavior

Boundary spanning is defined as an individual or team behavior that builds and manages external linkages with parties within an organization or across organizational boundaries (Kou, 2021; Marrone, 2010). It is generally classified into three broad categories: representation, task performance coordination, and general information search (Marrone *et al.*, 2021). Scholars have noted the positive effects of individual boundary spanning on individual job satisfaction, performance, and role overload (Liu *et al.*, 2018; Zhang and Li, 2021). Given the leaders' vital power and position in the workplace, they are expected to be key actors in connecting with external parties and obtaining valuable resources from in- and out-group members, thereby exhibiting boundary-spanning behavior (Salem *et al.*, 2018; Takanashi and Lee, 2019).

Leaders' boundary-spanning behavior comprises a broad set of externally-oriented activities, including persuading outsiders to provide support, acquiring critical information or resources from external stakeholders, and negotiating project contents directed toward people outside and within their organizations (Salem *et al.*, 2018). Despite its essential role, previous studies have largely overlooked its complex and subtle dynamics and focused solely on team boundary spanning (e.g. Zhang and Li, 2021). Building on the componential model of creativity (Amabile, 1983), this study concludes that leaders' boundary-spanning behavior promotes employees' creative behavior by increasing domain-relevant skills.

These leaders can increase domain-relevant skills, defined as "one's expertise or factual knowledge about the domain, technical skills for doing work and advancing one's knowledge in the domain, and special domain-relevant talents" (Amabile and Pratt, 2016, p. 160). According to the componential model of creativity (Amabile, 1983), domain-relevant skills are vital components for engaging in creative behavior. Boundary-spanning leaders who maintain close ties with external parties outside their teams or organizations can provide employees novel and insightful knowledge from external sources, facilitating knowledge circulation and enabling subordinates to navigate larger pools of resources and expertise

(Salem *et al.*, 2018). As focal employees are less accessible to critical external actors compared to leaders, employees can consider leaders' boundary-spanning behavior as an opportunity to access the information and knowledge required for creativity (Qu and Liu, 2021). Consequently, when leaders perform boundary-spanning behaviors, employees are likely to exhibit a high level of creative behavior. We expect the following:

H1. Leader boundary-spanning behavior is positively related to creative behavior.

Three-way interaction effects on creative behavior

We apply the interactionist perspective of organizational creativity (Woodman *et al.*, 1993) to better understand the drivers of employees' creative behavior, and examine how individual factors (i.e. the need for status and creative self-efficacy) jointly interact with situational factors (i.e. leaders' boundary-spanning behavior) to influence creative behavior. According to the componential model of creativity (Amabile, 1983), this study explores employees' need for status and creative self-efficacy as motivational and creativity-relevant components, respectively. We investigate a three-way effect between leaders' boundary-spanning behavior, the need for status, and creative self-efficacy.

Employees can acquire valuable resources (i.e. domain-relevant skills) from their boundary-spanning leaders, who have external information and expertise. However, they may not exhibit a high level of creative behavior without the necessary motivation and capacity to engage in such behavior. As task motivation is essential in facilitating creative behavior, our study highlights employees' need for status, which is one of the fundamental motivations for social relationships in the workplace (Weiss and Morrison, 2019).

Status, which is defined as respect, admiration, and voluntary deference, has been widely studied in various fields, including psychology, sociology, anthropology, economics, and organizational behavior (Anderson *et al.*, 2015). Scholars have stated that the desire to acquire status is a fundamental human motive (Kennedy *et al.*, 2013). Individuals with higher status tend to have greater subjective well-being, self-esteem, job satisfaction, and fewer intentions to quit. Hence, they may strive for a higher standing in the workplace (Weiss and Morrison, 2019). As a significant individual factor, the need for status is defined as a person's "motive to attain respect or admiration by others" (Dubois *et al.*, 2012, p. 1048). As creative behavior is promoted in the workplace, this study argues that the need for status could be a critical motivational factor that influences creative behavior. Thus, employees who possess a higher need for status may engage in creative behavior to enhance their status. Previous research has investigated the factors that increase individuals' status, such as personal characteristics, task expertise, and proactive behaviors (Weiss and Morrison, 2019). Weiss and Morrison (2019) have shown how voice behavior can promote the status of employees because it is healthy for a group's success. Similarly, we assume that creative behavior can be used as a tool to promote employees' status.

Although employees obtain domain-relevant skills from their boundary-spanning leaders and possess task motivation (i.e. a need for status), they may fail to exhibit high levels of creative behavior because of a lack of confidence in developing new ideas or building new ways of performing tasks, referred to as creative self-efficacy. Amabile and Pratt (2016) noted that creativity-relevant processes are individual-level factors, including cognitive style and skills that integrate raw materials into new ideas or products. Creative self-efficacy represents creativity-relevant processes that determine the ability to apply diverse information and attempt new perspectives required to demonstrate creative behaviors (Christensen-Salem *et al.*, 2021; Gong *et al.*, 2020). Tierney and Farmer (2002) defined creative self-efficacy as the belief that people can attain creative outcomes. Furthermore, they can quickly recover when encountering failures and attribute them to inadequate endeavors or scarce resources (Amabile and Pratt, 2016). Creative self-efficacy is necessary for creative

behavior as it involves [perseverance](#), initiation, and coping efforts ([Christensen-Salem et al., 2021](#)). We test a three-way interaction by integrating the componential model of creativity ([Amabile, 1983](#)) and the interactionist perspective of organizational creativity ([Woodman et al., 1993](#)). Consequently, we reason that the employees with a high need for status and creative self-efficacy have the motivation and capacity to combine diverse information and knowledge obtained from their boundary-spanning leaders, leading to the highest levels of creative behavior. We expect the following:

- H2.* There is a three-way effect of leader's boundary-spanning behavior, employees' need for status and employees' creative self-efficacy on employees' creative behavior: The level of creative behavior is highest when all three dimensions are high.

Methods

Sample and procedure

We distributed pairs of survey packages to students enrolled in an executive MBA program at a university in South Korea. We collected data from various companies mainly manufacturing, finance and IT services. Each survey package included a supervisor and subordinate surveys together with a reply envelope, which participants delivered directly to the researchers after completing the surveys. All participants were assured that their responses would remain confidential.

We initially had distributed questionnaires to 339 independent dyads and collected 267 dyads, giving a response rate of 79%. After matching the subordinate surveys with the corresponding supervisor surveys, a total of 260 pairs were used for final analyses representing a subordinate-supervisor ratio of 1.37:1. Among the responding supervisors, 87% were male with an average age 43.52 years old ($SD = 5.32$). Out of responding subordinates, 69% were male with an average age was 35.66 years old ($SD = 5.71$). The most frequently reported level of education for subordinates was a bachelor degree (77%).

Measures

All of the variables were used established measures and translated from English to Korean by using the conventional method of back translation ([Brislin, 1980](#)). In order to minimize potential common method bias effect ([Podsakoff et al., 2003](#)), employee creative behavior was rated by the employees' direct supervisor while other variables (i.e. leader's boundary-spanning behavior, need for status, creative self-efficacy and control variables) were rated by the employees. We measured all the items on a seven-point Likert-type scale (Ranging from 1 = strongly disagree to 7 = strongly agree).

Leader boundary-spanning behavior. We assessed leader's boundary-spanning behavior using 6 items of [Marrone et al.'s \(2007\)](#). A sample item is, "My team leader reaches out to individuals outside of our team that can provide project-related expertise or ideas".

Need for status. Need for status was rated by the employees using 8 items taken from [Flynn et al. \(2006\)](#). A sample item is, "Being a highly valued member of my social group is important to me".

Creative self-efficacy. We measured employees' creative self-efficacy using 3 items of [Tierney and Farmer \(2002\)](#) measure. A sample item is, "I have confidence in my ability to solve problems creatively".

Creative behavior. Employees' creative behavior was appraised by his/her direct supervisor using 13 items of [Zhou and George \(2001\)](#) measure. A sample item is, "This subordinate comes up with new and practical ideas to improve performance".

Control variables. Demographic variables including age, gender were measured from the employees to reduce the possibilities of unexpected influencing to this study results. Age was measured in years, gender was dummy coded (1 = male, 2 = female).

Results

The means, standard deviations, and correlations are provided in Table 1. Table 2 shows the results of the hierarchical multiple regression analyses with focal employees' creative behavior as the dependent variable.

We conducted hierarchical regression for testing our hypotheses. We input control and study variables in different steps of the equation. Consistent with H1, the multiple regression in Table 2 (Model 2) shows that leader's boundary-spanning behavior is positively related to employee's creative behavior ($\beta = 0.18, p < 0.01$). This result supports H1. H2 posited a three-way effect of leader's boundary-spanning behavior, employees' need for status and employees' creative self-efficacy such that the impact of leader's boundary-spanning behavior on employees' creative behavior is the strongest when need for status and creative self-efficacy of employees are both high. As can be seen in Table 2 (Model 4), the three-way effect among leader's boundary-spanning behavior, employees' need for status and employees' creative self-efficacy on employees' creative behavior is significant ($\beta = 0.15, p < 0.05$). To advance further interpretations, we plotted the high and low levels of each variable using the procedure outlined by Aiken and West (1991). Figure 1 depicts the pattern of the three-way result which supports H2.

Discussion

Most previous studies on leadership have focused on leaders' internal roles (Hughes *et al.*, 2018). Therefore, we highlight the critical role of leaders' boundary-spanning behavior that facilitates collaboration between actors inside and outside the organization to investigate this gap in the leadership literature (Marrone *et al.*, 2021; Salem *et al.*, 2018). Specifically, we reveal the positive effect of this behavior on employees' creative behavior. Furthermore, applying the componential model of creativity and an interactional perspective, we show a three-way effect on creative behavior by exploring leaders' boundary-spanning behavior, employees' need for status, and employees' creative self-efficacy.

Theoretical implications

This study makes several theoretical contributions to the literature. First, it provides new insights into boundary-spanning literature by examining the link between leaders' boundary-spanning behavior and employees' creative behavior. Prior studies have mainly focused on the positive effects of team boundary spanning on diverse outcomes, such as team effectiveness, innovation, and team viability (e.g. Kou, 2021), with only a few empirical studies examining the significant impact of individual boundary spanning on outcomes (Marrone *et al.*, 2021). There is a scarcity of research examining the effect of leaders' boundary-spanning behavior on outcomes (Salem *et al.*, 2018). Recent research has shown the positive effects of leaders'

Table 1.
Means, standard
deviations, reliabilities,
and correlations for
study variables

Variable	<i>M</i>	<i>SD</i>	1	2	3	4	5	6
1 Age ^a	35.66	5.72						
2 Gender ^a	1.31	0.46	−0.44***					
3 Leader boundary-spanning behavior ^a	5.69	0.96	0.13*	−0.17**	(0.93)			
4 Need for status ^a	4.83	0.87	−0.04	−0.14*	0.21**	(0.85)		
5 Creative self-efficacy ^a	5.05	1.04	0.22***	−0.38***	0.37***	0.25***	(0.88)	
6 Creative behavior ^b	4.72	1.08	0.09	−0.13*	0.20**	0.09	0.30***	(0.98)

Note(s): *N* = 260. Reliabilities are on the diagonal in parentheses
* $p < 0.05$; ** $p < 0.01$; *** $p < 0.001$ (two-tailed).^a Self-rated; ^b Supervisor-rated

	Model 1	Creative behavior		Model 4
		Model 2	Model 3	
<i>Step 1. Control variables</i>				
Age	0.04	0.03	0.02	0.04
Gender	-0.11	-0.08	0.00	-0.01
<i>Step 2. Main effect</i>				
Leader boundary-spanning behavior		0.18**	0.10	0.09
<i>Step 3. Main effect</i>				
Need for status			0.01	-0.01
Creative self-efficacy			0.26***	0.23**
<i>Step 4. Interaction</i>				
Leader boundary-spanning behavior* Need for status				0.03
Leader boundary-spanning behavior* Creative self-efficacy				0.10
Need for status* Creative self-efficacy				-0.01
Leader boundary-spanning behavior* Need for status* Creative self-efficacy				0.15*
Overall <i>F</i>	2.28	4.31**	5.73***	3.81***
<i>R</i> ²	0.02	0.05	0.10	0.12
ΔF		8.23**	7.54**	1.36
ΔR^2		0.03	0.05	0.02

Note(s): *N* = 260. * *p* < 0.05; ** *p* < 0.01; *** *p* < 0.001 (two-tailed). ^a Entries are standardized regression coefficients

Table 2.
Hierarchical regression
results for creative
behavior^a

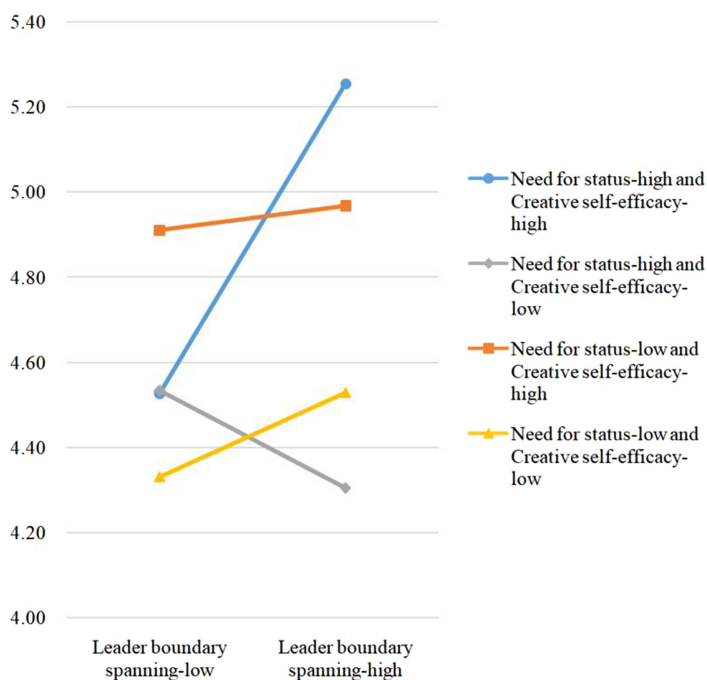


Figure 1.
Three-way effect
between leader
boundary spanning-
behavior, need for
status and creative self-
efficacy

supportive coaching of boundary-spanning behavior on employees' boundary-spanning self-efficacy, which in turn leads to employees' boundary-spanning behavior (e.g. [Marrone et al., 2021](#)). Based on previous research, this study explores leaders' boundary-spanning behavior and how it positively affects employees' creative behavior at the individual level. Future research should investigate the effects of boundary-spanning behavior from specific actors in the workplace. For example, it would be worthwhile to examining the role of coworker or employee boundary spanning to enhance proactive behaviors such as voice behavior. Boundary spanning employees are likely to speak up to improve the situations since they have diverse knowledge and information than others.

Second, our study contributes to the creative literature by exploring leaders' boundary-spanning behavior and contextual factors based on the componential model and an interactional perspective of creativity. Our findings show that a boundary-spanning leader may provide an opportunity for their employees to obtain domain-relevant skills, which helps promote employees' creative behavior. Moreover, we empirically test how leaders' boundary-spanning behavior, need for status, and creative self-efficacy, representing the three components of domain-relevant skills, creativity-relevant processes, and task motivation, respectively, influence employees' creative behavior. Previous research has applied the componential model of creativity and demonstrated how the components are critical in influencing employees' creative behavior ([Kim et al., 2021](#)). For instance, scholars have identified high-commitment work systems as creative situational factors that enhance domain-relevant skills, creativity-relevant processes, and task motivation ([Chang et al., 2014](#)). [Kwan et al. \(2018\)](#) examined task resources and creative process engagement as creativity-relevant processes that foster employees' creative behavior. [Hirst et al. \(2009\)](#) noted that learning-goal orientation could promote employees' creative behavior by increasing domain-relevant skills and task motivation. In this study, we explore all three components and demonstrate the simultaneous interactions among these variables.

In addition, this study draws on theories of person–situation interactions and uses three-way interactions to advance an understanding of employees' creative behavior by examining individual and situational factors. [Cai et al. \(2019\)](#) noted that creativity is predicted to be highest when psychological capital, supervisor support for creativity, and job characteristics are high. [Shao et al. \(2019\)](#) demonstrated how creative self-efficacy mediates the three-way interactions between paradoxical leader behavior, workload pressure, and integrative complexity on creativity. [Zhang et al. \(2017\)](#) demonstrated the three-way interactions between job autonomy, psychological performance pressure, and learning-goal orientation in predicting creativity. Based on prior studies, we have examined the need for status and creative self-efficacy as individual factors, whereas leaders' boundary-spanning behavior has been explored as a situational factor. Future research should continue to apply the componential model and an interactional perspective and investigate how various contextual factors influence employees' creative behavior.

Finally, our study contributes to the leadership literature by exploring leader-specific behavior, such as boundary-spanning behavior. Most studies have focused on leaders' internal activities and their effects on various outcomes, including creative behavior ([Mehmood et al., 2021](#)). For instance, [Hughes et al. \(2018\)](#) investigated transformational leadership, empowering leadership, benevolent leadership, servant leadership, authentic leadership, and supervisor support as the determinants of creative behavior. Although leaders' external activities may have positive impacts, there is a lack of research examining the role of leaders' boundary-spanning behavior in the workplace. Thus, our study is meaningful as it demonstrates the effect of leaders' boundary-spanning behavior on creative behavior. Future research should investigate the roles of leaders' boundary-spanning behaviors in the workplace. It is possible that leaders' boundary spanning is positively related to various employee outcomes, including task performance, organizational citizenship behavior, and knowledge-sharing behavior. Predictably, individuals

who receive resources from their boundary-spanning leaders are likely to engage in prosocial behavior. They are likely to feel obligations and thus engage in citizenship behavior or share their knowledge with others as reciprocity. Moreover, it is worthwhile to examining the possible negative effects of leader boundary spanning on outcomes in future research. Since it requires time and effort to engage in boundary-spanning behavior, leader who performs boundary-spanning behavior may perceive a high level of stress or role overload in the workplace. Those leaders may suffer from balancing their internal roles as well as boundary spanning roles. Future research should investigate the positive effect of leader's boundary spanning on role overload or job stress.

Practical implications

This research has important practical implications. First, our study shows that leaders' boundary-spanning behavior is crucial in evoking employees' creative behavior. Our findings suggest that organizations should promote leaders' boundary-spanning behavior, thereby enhancing employees' creative behavior. Based on our findings of the research, we recommend that leaders should interact with individuals outside of their team to obtain various information and ideas that could be transferred to their employees. Organizations should find specific ways to promote leaders' boundary-spanning behavior. For example, given its resource-intensive nature, organizations should design structures and systems that could encourage boundary spanning. Organization should provide instrumental and emotional support including incentives or rewards for boundary spanning leaders.

In addition, organizations can help leaders develop their networks, a key antecedent of boundary-spanning behavior (Brion *et al.*, 2012), by providing opportunities to connect with other actors to exchange diverse information and knowledge. They may consider holding periodic meetings with diverse teams or units that encourage knowledge sharing practices. Rotating jobs, teams or locations could be helpful to understand external parties and transfer the information effectively. Also, conducting leadership training or development activities is necessary to promote leaders' boundary-spanning behavior. Specifically, it is critical to develop communication and interpersonal skills that help sustain contact with other units or teams.

It is important to build organizational culture valuing externally-oriented activities. If organizational culture promotes flexibility, openness, and sharing knowledge, leaders may feel easier to perform boundary-spanning behavior. Moreover, organizations should provide autonomy for leaders to demonstrate boundary-spanning behaviors (e.g. Marrone *et al.*, 2021). When leaders do not have sufficient discretion to interact with external parties, it is difficult to exhibit such behaviors.

Second, our study highlights the critical role of individual factors, such as the need for status and creative self-efficacy, and situational factors that determine the level of creative behavior. Gong *et al.* (2020) demonstrated how the diversity of social ties increases creative self-efficacy and thereby, creativity. Their study highlights the importance of diversity in social ties and the strength of such ties as predictors of creative self-efficacy. Thus, it may be helpful for organizations to increase functional diversity to promote employees' creative self-efficacy, as providing resources is critical for boosting creative self-efficacy. Moreover, prior research has shown the critical role of leadership styles, such as empowering and transformational leadership, in enhancing creative self-efficacy (e.g. Puente-Díaz, 2016). Thus, organizations should train their leaders to build appropriate leadership styles to promote creative self-efficacy among employees. This study's findings suggest the vital role of individual factors; it would be fruitful for organizations to consider individual attributes, such as a high need for status or high creative self-efficacy, when selecting employees and assigning jobs that require creative tasks.

Limitations and future research

Despite above contributions, this study has a few limitations. First, cross-sectional data of this study precludes from inferring causality. It would be beneficial to conduct future research implementing longitudinal or field-experimental research designs to ensure the causality of the relationships examined in this study. Second, we cannot rule out a potential risk of common method bias although we collected data from different sources. Third, our research is designed as a focused study which included limited variables. Future research should consider the effect of mediating variables and determine the mechanism between leaders' boundary-spanning and employees' creative behaviors. For example, employees working with boundary-spanning leaders may perceive diverse resources to promote creative behavior.

Despite these limitations, this study sheds light on the understanding of boundary-spanning behavior, particularly leaders' boundary-spanning behavior, and its effects on employees' creative behavior. Applying the componential model and interactional perspective of creativity, our study demonstrates the importance of developing creative conditions by simultaneously providing domain-relevant skills, creativity-relevant processes, and task motivation to promote employees' creative behavior.

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